

Dissecting the economic, cultural, political, gendered and historical aspects of cross-border engagements with respect to India, this volume succeeds in starting a conversation with related approaches such as colonialism and intersectionality and provides a firm grounding for analysing the Indian case in a global perspective.

Thomas Faist, Professor of Sociology, Bielefeld University, Germany

This timely volume offers a path-breaking collection of essays on transnationalism with special reference to India and the Indian diaspora. Supported by detailed historical research, both traditional and web-based, each essay interrogates global disjunctures, unequal power structures, gender hierarchies and social and ethnic collisions that underlie the politics of migration, borders, homeland narratives, cosmopolitanism and the changing definitions of the nation state.

***Vijay Mishra, Professor of English and Comparative Literature,
Murdoch University, Australia***

This is an excellent collection of essays that includes the entire gamut of themes relating to Indian transnationalism – from migrant workers (labourers and skilled professionals), implications for culture and identity, political and gender dynamics and global networks – which would appeal to scholars and students of sociology, anthropology, history, geography and diaspora studies.

***Brij Maharaj, Professor of Geography, University of KwaZulu-Natal,
South Africa***

ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF INDIAN TRANSNATIONALISM

This book introduces readers to the many dimensions of historical and contemporary Indian transnationalism and the experiences of migrants and workers to reveal the structures of transnationalism and the ways in which Indian origin groups are affected.

The concept of crossing borders emerges as an important theme, along with the interweaving of life in geographic and web spaces. The authors draw from a variety of archives and intellectual perspectives in order to map the narratives of Indian transnationalism and analyse the interplay of culture and structures within transnational contexts. The topics covered range from the history of transnational networks, activism, identity, gender, politics, labour, policy, performance, literature and more. This collection presents a wide array of issues and debates which will reinvigorate discussions about Indian transnationalism.

This handbook will be an invaluable resource for academics, researchers and students interested in studying South Asia in general and the Indian diaspora in particular.

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EXPERIENCES OF EMPOWERMENT AND CONSTRAINT

Narratives of transnational Indian women entrepreneurs

Manashi Ray

Introduction

Despite enormous advances made in immigrant entrepreneurship literature beginning with Bonacich (1973), Light and Bonacich (1988), and others (Light and Bachu 1993; Zhou and Logan 1989; Aldrich and Waldinger 1990; Light and Gold 2000, etc.), including ethnic group-specific research (Gold 1998, 1994; Gold and Kibria, 1993; Zhou 1992; Hosler 1998; Min 1988; Min and Bozorgmehr 2000; Basu and Goswami 1999; Ram 1994; among others), gender has been under-investigated in immigrant economies. Women have often been described as ‘silent contributors’ (Dhaliwal 1998) to male-run businesses, facilitating the success of immigrant economies by providing unpaid labour as an extension of their domestic, maternal, and socially reproductive household activities (Zhou and Logan 1989). This has been denounced as ‘exploitation’ or explained as women’s ‘traditional’ place in immigrant cultures (Zhou 1992, 152–84). Since the early 2000s this changed, with steadily growing research addressing women and immigrant women in particular as entrepreneurs, innovators, and businesswomen who use their class, ethnic, culture, and gender resources for starting and sustaining businesses in ethnic and mainstream economies (Knight 2016; Valdez 2011; Javadian and Singh 2012; Collins and Low 2010; Tan 2008; Lee et al. 2009; Rutashobya, Allan, and Nilsson 2009; Brettell 2007; and others).

However, no research addresses how women realise entrepreneurial aspirations across national borders or how gender relations affect transnational entrepreneurship and vice versa. Similarly, little research studies highly skilled migrant women entrepreneurs’ use of human and cultural capital for entrepreneurship, as most research focuses on the ‘push’ elements driving their engagement in entrepreneurship, such as discrimination and marginalisation in the labour market, unemployment, poverty, the need to provide for family, dissatisfaction with past/present employers, and cultural norms (Azmat 2013; Poggesi, Mari, and De Vita 2016, 751–52). But women may also be ‘pulled’ into entrepreneurial enterprise to pursue opportunities to develop ideas, earn a higher income or for self-fulfilment, be their own boss, or

leverage cross-border resources (Tan 2008). These aspects have received scant attention in empirical research. This chapter, therefore, makes a vital contribution by studying the specific experiences of migrant and returnee¹ Asian Indian women who are owners or co-owners/partners of transnational businesses located in the US and India. It explores several aspects of these women's entrepreneurial experiences that impact their entry into transnational business, including education, professional career, English-language proficiency, class background, migratory process, membership in multiple networks, and family. I investigate how they draw extensively on these forms of human, cultural, class, social, and ethnic capital that define their experiences and empowerment as women transnational entrepreneurs (TEs) at different stages of entrepreneurship and during their life course.

I first show how US immigration policy changes, dramatic shifts in Indian state policies since the 1980s, and selective migration from India created an enabling economic and political environment that resonated with Indian women migrants' aspirations to initiate transnational entrepreneurship and influenced the location of their businesses. I then present several typical cases illustrating the resources women entrepreneurs bring to their enterprises that redefine gender expectations and thus entrepreneurial experiences. Finally, I consider the heterogeneity and complexity of their experiences and examine changing nuances of gender relations.

Methods

The experiences of women transnational entrepreneurs discussed in this chapter were collected during fieldwork in the US and India over a ten-year period (2007–2017/18) by conducting narrative interviews in multiple urban centres in both countries. For longitudinal analysis, a few women were interviewed again eight to ten years after the initial interview, to capture if and how they dealt with family responsibilities at different life stages and how this affected their business growth. As Indian migrants are a widely dispersed population in the US (Portes and Rumbaut 2014), I sought multiple data sources to obtain a representative sample of migrant and returnee women entrepreneurs from wide-ranging business sectors (info-tech, professional services, manufacturing, and retail/wholesale). First, the interviewees were selected via snowballing with the help of personal networks of family and friends to gather information about women transnational entrepreneurs residing in both countries. Second, I used public data sources on the web and the mailing lists of Indian trade and business associations to build a roster of potential respondents' names, office addresses, and type/sector of transnational business in the US and India. In India, I visited the office of NASSCOM (The National Association of Software & Service Companies) in New Delhi, where I interviewed the secretary and officials of this premier trade institution of the Information Technology-Business Process Outsourcing (IT-BPO) industries. Respondents' business offices were contacted directly by email and phone for interviews. To supplement the primary data, I used secondary data from the Department of Homeland Security's Office of Immigration Statistics (OIS) for 2016, Pew Research Center and Migration Policy Institute publications, and online articles to analyse transnational business trends among Indians.

The interviews lasted one to two hours. Topical questions were prepared beforehand covering educational background, the societal or institutional structures that contributed to respondents' cultural and social capital, occupational history, migratory moves (including their decision for returning to India), and the respondents' utilisation of diverse networks. But the interviewees were encouraged to elaborate on aspects of their lives they considered important and to provide in-depth interpretation of any episodes. The interviews were conducted in English and Hindi and were recorded and transcribed verbatim. Pseudonyms are used to protect identity.

The respondents were born in India, range from forty-three to sixty-two years old, and have been owners and founders or partners of transnational businesses between ten and thirty years. All the respondents were married, excluding three, and all had children except for two.

Framing the case: immigration from India to the US

Contemporary migration from India to the US, according to Chakravorty, Kapur, and Singh (2016), can be divided into three major phases: 1) the ‘Early Movers’ (1965–1979); 2) the ‘Families’ (1980–1994); and 3) the ‘IT Generation’, which represent the profiles of an estimated 3.98 million Asian Indians living in the US (Pew Research Center 2017). The revision of the Immigration and Naturalization Act of 1965, a momentous shift in US immigration policy, allowed the admittance of a large number of skilled professionals and students from India for the first time. Many highly trained Indian migrants took advantage of the visa allocation preference given to ‘priority workers; professionals with advanced degrees, or aliens of exceptional ability’, contributing to the ‘brain drain’ from India at that time.

While this movement corresponded to a significant gain for the US in highly trained and skilled personnel (Portes and Rumbaut 2014), there was also a corresponding ‘push’ factor in India: the transformation of the social basis of political power as a consequence of universal franchise. Over time this policy permitted the ascendancy of marginalised groups while gradually eroding the social and political power of elites and upper castes, leading them to migrate abroad for better prospects. Furthermore, Chakravorty, Kapur, and Singh (2016, 27–31) note the existence of a well-ingrained selection process for the best and brightest Indians who voluntarily chose to leave for the US. The social system favoured individuals from urban, educated, and higher/dominant classes and castes to receive higher education, and an examination system selected individuals from this socially privileged group to be trained in technical fields. These factors complement the US immigration system’s selection process, which prefers individuals with specific technical skills, particularly in IT since the 1990s.

In the mid-1970s the immigration flow from India shifted towards family reunification (phase 2) as the early settlers sponsored family members, relatives, and kin. This became the predominant mode of Indians entering the US until the late 1980s. Although these immigrants were educationally accomplished by American and Indian standards, they were less so in comparison to the ‘Early Movers’. Twenty-five years later, another revision of immigration law—the Immigration Act of 1990—substantially increased the number of technical and specialty temporary workers arriving in the US under the temporary H-1B visa program, which has become the primary channel for the arrival of huge numbers of skilled professional Indian migrants (phase 3, the ‘IT generation’). Additionally, throughout the three phases mentioned above, Indians have entered the US as students pursuing higher education.

During this period India’s domestic policies underwent drastic changes that powerfully influenced migration from India to northern countries. After the Cold War and particularly from the mid-1980s, India replaced socialistic-leaning policies with ‘pro-business’ development strategies, like many emerging economies. The government became highly interventionist² by giving precedence to economic growth as a national goal (Kohli 2007). Domestic policies shifted due to global changes and domestic compulsions, thus impacting policies towards the Indian diaspora. Changes in foreign policy particularly targeted influential Non-Resident Indians (NRI), wherever they settled, to engage in the Indian economy, services, academics, politics, health sector, and entrepreneurship. To that end, the government started the innovative Overseas Citizenship of India (OCI) scheme, which granted overseas Indians Indian citizenship and other benefits, though they could not participate in elections or hold

constitutional posts. The OCI scheme's main intention was to facilitate economic investment from NRIs without giving them political rights and to bring capital and investment into India (Tiwari 2013, 223). The government provided special savings, investment schemes, and instruments for NRIs, such as foreign currency accounts, bonds with attractive interest rates, and tax benefits to encourage saving and investment (Tiwari 2013, 212–30). Further, starting in 1991, import quotas were lifted (albeit not fully until 2001), tariffs declined steadily, currency was devalued, the foreign investment regime was liberalised, and restrictions on external financial transactions were eased. These policy changes signalled that the state had entered into a new social contract with Indian businesses, supporting them with the understanding that they had to become more competitive in the international arena. As a result of these dramatic shifts in political, economic, and social policies, between the 1980s and 2005, India's economy grew from the world's fiftieth largest, in nominal US dollars, to the tenth largest (Ahmed and Varshney 2012). And India has remained the top international remittance-receiving nation in the world, with \$62.7 billion in 2016 (World Bank 2017), despite the recent decline of remittances by 8.9 percent for two successive years.

The biggest beneficiary of these policy revisions has been the IT sector. Indian expatriates in the US have played a crucial role in India's global integration through the transfer of technology, social and financial remittance, start-up capital, and mobilising capital from well-established entrepreneurs (Saxenian 2006; Gold 2018). The Indian state wishes to maximise 'brain gain/circulation/return' and use foreign-trained Indian immigrants and nationals as a magnet for foreign and diasporic investments in knowledge-based industries (Kapur and Ramamurti 2001). This opening of the Indian economy to the global market presented an unprecedented opportunity to the overseas Indian migrant community, and particularly to Asian Indians in the US, to invest and establish business with India. Given their own professional success and resources, members of this community in the US felt compelled to participate in India's economic growth and development. By 2002 the combination of a recession in Silicon Valley, enormous difficulties with complicated and outdated immigration laws (Wadhwa and Salkever 2012), and growing professional and entrepreneurial opportunities in India prompted an ongoing and sustained interest among US-educated Indians, particularly in STEM fields, to initiate transnational business ventures with India (Saxenian 2006). India thus reversed the 'brain drain' of earlier decades by establishing 'brain gain/circulation' opportunities for Indian migrants in the US (Ray 2013).

Consequently, this makes the 'context of exit' for contemporary Indian migrants a selective process inspired by a complex range of motives, and one that affects their career paths and assimilation/acculturation in American society. Indian migrants' major modes of entry to the US (either as international students or H-1B workers³ filling jobs requiring a university degree) create a positive image for this ethnic group, which comprised 2.4 million immigrant residents in 2015 with a median age of thirty-nine years. With 68 percent employed in the civilian labour force in 2015, the group's occupational profile demonstrates a close association between high levels of education (77% ages twenty-five and over with a bachelor's degree or higher) and their socio-economic location in American society, with their median household income at \$107,000 (Zong and Batalova 2017). These figures strongly reflect the specific channels Indian use to enter the US.

Theory

For all entrepreneurs, irrespective of gender, mobilising resources is key to their success. Cross-border networks are especially critical for the growth and survival of transnational

entrepreneurship, just as networks are imperative for entrepreneurs from immigrant and dominant groups. While TEs hold considerable class and ethnic resources, transnational networks provide access to information, markets, capital, technology, mentoring, and emotional support (Davidsson and Honig 2003; Light and Gold 2000). These networks enable them to combine connections, resources, and identities from multiple locations to maximise their independence from restrictions associated with societal hierarchies, gender ideologies, patriotism, and citizenship (Gold 2002, 13).

Cross-border networks connect the demand side and the supply side, structures and resources, and opportunities and individuals at different levels (Chen and Tan 2009). As a meso-level analytical framework,⁴ cross-border networks help to focus on the *relationships* entrepreneurs have that offer resources for transnational business endeavours (Granovetter 1992; Greve and Salaff 2003). As Light and Gold (2000) mention, ‘the contribution of social networks to entrepreneurship is the most important research discovery in the last generation’ (94). It is therefore no surprise that scholars have extensively used social networks for examining transnational migration, entrepreneurship, settlement patterns, and other engagements (Poros 2011; Landolt 2001; Levitt 2001; among others).

But, membership and use of transnational networks and economic practices are decidedly affected by migrants’ and non-migrants’ diverse motivations and forms of resource mobilisation. The use of these networks also depends on migrants’ social locations in their home and host countries, their ‘context of exit’, and other ascribed characteristics, notwithstanding their shared ethnic membership or nationality. Only recently has the importance of non-economic resources—family, identity, community, philanthropic and nationalistic aspirations—been emphasised as vital to the success of cross-border businesses. These resources add value and complement global business strategies and innovation (Gold 2018; Salaff, Wong, and Greve 2010; Ray 2013). Members consider network relationships to be priceless for providing ‘social capital’—a sense of commitment or mutual obligation that motivates people to extend favours, expect preferential treatment, and look out for each other. Social capital defines the depth and durability of networks and interlocks actors in long-term relationships, and its consumption usually increases rather than depletes its availability in a given context (Rutashobya, Allan, and Nilsson 2009; Gold 2005).

However, differential social capital accumulation within networks can affect productive capacity and thereby create unequal outcomes for members. Hence dissimilarities in entrepreneurial performance among various groups in migrant populations can be explained by differential access to social capital within a network or by differential possession of other forms of capital (human, cultural, and financial). Specifically, in the context of transnational migration and subsequent cross-border business, Bourdieu’s notion of capital provides a deeper description of how different forms of capital interact, resulting in iniquitous outcomes for TEs.

Bourdieu and Wacquant (1992) emphasise the overall composition of an individual’s capital, made up of economic (income, wealth, financial inheritances, and assets), social (resources based on connections, group membership generated in social networks), and cultural capital. Cultural capital can take three forms: embodied (long-lasting disposition of mind and body, e.g., bi-cultural literacy, English language proficiency), objectified (cultural goods), and institutionalised (educational degrees). As these forms of capital are recognised as legitimate, they become symbolic capital. Bourdieu contends that these different forms of capital are interlinked and convertible.

Closely associated with ‘capital’ is Bourdieu’s ‘theory of practice’ (1990), which is related to an individual’s ‘habitus’. Bourdieu defines habitus as a

product of history that produces individual and collective practices . . . it ensures the active presence of past experiences, which, deposited in each organism in the form of schemes of perception, thought and action, tend to guarantee the ‘correctness’ of practices and their constancy over time, more reliably than all formal rules and explicit norms.

(cited in Drori, Honig, and Ginsberg 2010, 7)

Habitus informs practices or strategies that might not be planned or explicit but that ‘guide the individual entrepreneur in managing change and uncertainty’ (Drori, Honig, and Ginsberg 2010, 8). The TE’s habitus is a product of material and social conditioning echoing one’s experiences because of one’s social location, and collectively constitutes a ‘class habitus’, learned in immediate and extended family, school, and neighbourhood (Light and Gold 2000, 92–94).

For the habitus to be produced and activated, the notion of ‘field’ becomes important. A network of relations can be defined as a ‘field’⁵ wherein different kinds of capital (social, economic, cultural, and symbolic) are embedded and individuals strategize to gain degrees of control (Drori, Honig, and Ginsberg 2010; adapting from Bourdieu and Wacquant 1992). Put differently, ‘at the individual level, the *habitus* interacts with the collective through common relationship of the field’, and thus the relationship of the habitus and the accompanying ‘field’ explain the predisposition of entrepreneurs towards action at the intersection of the collective and the individual (Drori, Honig, and Ginsberg 2010, 9).

Bourdieu is often critiqued for theorising ‘class formation’ within a nation-state framework, but his model can include sources of capital produced and utilised in more than one country. Several scholars have adopted Bourdieu’s framework, like Nowicka’s (2013) research on Polish entrepreneurs in Germany highlighting how the use of economic, social, and cultural capital acquired in different countries helps position entrepreneurial strategies for success. Similarly, Erel (2010) uses Bourdieu’s concepts to illustrate the transformative aspects of migration-specific capital and how skilled Turkish and Kurdish women in Britain are able to valorise their cultural resources as capital in their country of residence. Additionally, Kelly and Lusi (2006) use Bourdieu’s habitus to explain that economic, social, and cultural capital do not simply transfer to new settings but that a process of valuation and exchange continues between home and host countries well after settlement. Thus the role of transnational networks and the intersection of different forms of capital in the process of migration—over time and between geographical sites—is crucial for analysing ways existing capital or resources brought from the home country are appreciated and transformed or acquired in the host country within transnational fields.

Women transnational entrepreneurs

In this section I trace the trajectories of women TEs who have engaged in cross-border entrepreneurship, primarily between the US and India. These case studies show the wider complexities of migration and strategies and constraints for transnational entrepreneurship. For some women, immense personal effort and determination, combined with social networks, was required to migrate for better opportunities, while for others it was the pursuit of higher education and global recognition. Family trajectories mattered as well, particularly the partner’s migratory history and professional growth and progression, as many decisions to migrate and pursue an entrepreneurial career were taken within the immediate and extended family. Not everyone had a choice. These case studies illustrate that a confluence of factors—motives, choices, opportunities, available resources, and support systems—and a combination of successive migratory and professional movements led these women to entrepreneurship across multiple national borders.

***The power couples: Kavita, Rekha, Vani, Tara, Gowri,
Rukmini, and Durga***

Kavita, Rekha, Vani, Tara, and Gowri migrated to the US in the mid- to late 1990s as graduate students in STEM fields, except for Vani, who received her terminal degree in law. Among the seven respondents whom I call ‘power couples’, only Rukmini and Durga entered the US as spouses when their husbands were either transferred by their companies or decided to relocate to the US from the UK. Kavita’s inspiration for migrating to the US as a single woman was pursuing a PhD:

I had a senior college friend who had come to the University of X. He convinced one [of] his professors, who had a lot of projects, having preference for Indian students. This prof. made funds available for me to go to the US. I was a gold medallist from my university, which helped getting a quarter-time assistantship for the first semester. After that I supported myself.

Tara also migrated to pursue an advanced degree:

This urge to go to the US was always behind me so I decided to leave home . . . my father was very supportive of me coming to the US to study. I’m sure they were very worried about sending a girl alone to the US, I was one of the top rankers in my class so he felt this was my opportunity to fulfil my potentials . . . my mother was sad but gave in. I had got admission in a few universities; I chose to be at R as my aunt lived in a town close to the university.

Vani and Gowri stated similar reasons for their migration. Gowri said:

When I was growing up that was the American dream. One was to get into A [premier Indian institution] and the second was to go to the US. [The] American dream existed in our campus . . . it was the normal course of things then . . . a kind of herd mentality. For me going to the US was an independent decision, although if I had not met my partner I might have done something else. So it was both influenced by my fiancé and my brother who had gone to the US ahead of me.

Being female and ‘single’ might have been concerning in the Indian context, where conventional gender roles place reproductive and household duties before the pursuit of higher education, but the women’s individual human and class capital, context of exit, and having family members and friends in the US outweighed these concerns. Another respondent, Rukmini, was established in her advertising career in India but chose to be a full-time ‘homemaker’ during her stay in the US. The other four women met their partners, who were graduate students in similar disciplines, in the US, and entered the US labour force together as couples.

What is striking in these narratives is the women’s agency, even though their migratory decisions were supported by family members and influenced by their peers and the macro environments in the premier institutions they attended. These women left their home countries in their twenties for self-actualisation and to fortify their human capital. But their independent streak and the values that shaped their personalities reflect the embodied cultural capital of urban, Western-educated, professional upper-middle-class or rich backgrounds in India, which helped them adapt to multicultural American society and validated their cultural capital brought from home. The cultural capital within the Indian families in which they were raised—irrespective

Manashi Ray

of region and caste—set in place the mechanisms that redrew boundaries and expectations for them, so that defiance of normative gender roles was tolerated and encouraged.

When questioned on this issue, Vani, Rekha, Rukmini, and others fiercely rejected the notion of being undervalued compared to male siblings, stressing the privileges of being girls/women in their families as impartial and gratifying, with a strong emphasis on education, as evident in these recollections:

The way we grew up maybe was slightly different from others in India. It was different because we were encouraged to make our own decisions from a very early age and all three of us read a lot. Looking back I feel I had a lot of freedom from my childhood. . . . We also had many discussions at the kitchen table, my parents encouraged plenty of debates on various issues, we were asked to speak and voice our thoughts.

(Rekha)

. . . my dad adored his three daughters, made us feel like we were the most important people on this earth and provided for us the very best that could be offered in India—best school, the best opportunities in nurturing my passion for performing arts, sports, social life, etc. That gave me confidence and courage to take on the world.

(Rukmini)

These women's cosmopolitan upbringing, English-language proficiency, and bi-cultural literacy were assets and markers of distinction that they could easily convert into economic capital upon joining the US labour force as professional workers. All the respondents in this category except two were employed in middle and upper management in engineering or technological multinational corporations or in scientific research laboratories for five to ten years in the US before transitioning to entrepreneurship. Rukmini honed her skills in 'communication and advertising' by volunteering in Indian and American organisations, whereas Durga, a delayed entrepreneur,⁶ waited until her children went to college to start her cross-border business in event management and real estate.

There was no clear-cut separation of push and pull factors for these interviewees; rather, it was a combination of both, and life course events—like raising children, care-giving responsibilities for aging parents, a partner's relocation—that motivated them to entrepreneurship in partnership or with unequivocal support and mentoring from their spouses, who were also TEs. Nor did these women TEs perceive potential difficulties in integrating family and professional life, defying the notion that entrepreneurship is detrimental to balancing family and work life (Poggesi, Mari, and De Vita 2016, 744). Rather, they asserted it was a deep desire for self-expression, achievement, and empowerment along with an enabling ecosystem that propelled them to entrepreneurship—an important reflection of how their understanding of gender expectations, their career stages, and family status influenced their high-growth entrepreneurship.

Further, obtaining greater autonomy was important for these women, along with the joy, success, and satisfaction of building relationships with customers and employees and accomplishing something they considered worthwhile. Kavita explained:

I worked for five years in the industry and as an independent consultant a couple of years in the Silicon Valley . . . it was when [the] web was booming, people were starting out companies here, . . . it was contagious, I wanted to do something exciting next. In the end, my husband who is an electrical engineer and I decided to float

a company that would look into the software needs of the pharmaceutical industry. My husband had been [an] entrepreneur for a long time. Raising a family comes with the territory.

Similarly, Gowri said:

I am one of those persons who [has] a big appetite of taking risks . . . perhaps the risk-taking ability has been my strength and an enduring trait that has served me well, so transitioning to entrepreneurship was predictable and easy. My husband had [a] finance background, I had more IT kind of background besides being a ‘people’ person. . . . So, [the] decision about being the CEO has to do with [an] individual’s forte. My husband had no issues about me being the face of the company. In the end I think it has worked out well for us both professionally and at home. We share parenting equally and other familial responsibilities. It’s [a] team!

Rekha also expressed similar sentiments, describing her and her partner’s success and satisfaction with their business in the technology sector after seventeen years:

It was the best decision we made together. As we were among the first few to return to India in 2000, nothing was laid out, there were no procedures then, I discovered as I went along . . . which is my strength and gives me a huge sense of satisfaction.

As successful first-generation TEs from elite backgrounds, their enterprises were aided by the spreading of new technology, the diversity of organisations, and the global economy, which has erased many older stereotypes and substantially reduced structural barriers for women since the mid- to late 1990s.

Above all, the power couples took advantage of a strong and enabling entrepreneurial ecosystem found on both the East and West coasts of the US and the prevailing ‘culture of co-operation’, a ‘work culture where openness, complementary skill sets and collaboration is rewarded’ (Gold 2018, 137). But, their success was driven by their access to social capital, embedded in multiple networks (peer, co-ethnic, educational institutions’ alumni networks, professional, trade, and familial networks), where they received guidance, funding, referrals, advice, and support that augmented their business connections. Wadhwa and Salkever (2012) recall the monumental contribution of the first generation of successful Indian entrepreneurs in Silicon Valley, who built organisations like the Indus Entrepreneurs⁷ to help those who followed in their path. These pioneer Indian entrepreneurs, who overcame stereotypes and cultural challenges, shared their experience and knowledge to ease the entry of other Indian TEs, including women (Chakravorty, Kapur, and Singh 2016).

Notably, these women also attributed their entrepreneurial success to previous work experience in the industry, to supportive husbands who in all seven cases were equally connected to extensive networks, and to their synergy with their spouses. The couples’ financial and emotional security allowed the women TEs to withstand failures and setbacks in their enterprises and to take more risks for their businesses’ long-term growth, a finding that resonates with Tan’s (2008) study of Chinese women entrepreneurs in the electronics industry. So, for these women TEs, one’s entrepreneurial career was as much environmental as personal and the product of a combination of cultural and social capital and migratory exposure that encouraged creativity focused on transnational entrepreneurship.

The inheritors: Maya, Sonia, and Deepa

For Maya, Sonia, and Deepa, entrepreneurship was a natural progression as their lives unfolded. All three were born into well-established, multi-generational business families in India belonging to a prosperous merchant community and caste. Sonia explained,

I knew as a girl this to be my life's aspiration, though I was given complete freedom to make choices . . . for my career, go abroad to study . . . entrepreneurship is in my blood. The women in our family have always been discreetly involved in business as trust or board members, partners, shareholders, etc. . . . I wanted to be on [the] forefront, create opportunities and help my dad!

All three respondents travelled overseas—to the US, France, and the UK—for graduate education in business, food and beverage management, and supply-chain management. As part of their families' business expansion into global markets in the mid-2000s, Sonia and Deepa resettled in the US with their families, making substantial investments in assets/property in the US and the American market. Maya, however, chose to work alongside her father in India. She said:

He definitely needed me . . . we mutually learnt from each other. I work in his industry and in our family business. He taught me the nuts and bolts of how to operate the business and the tremendous amount of attention to detail that is needed to hold everything together . . . so that we sustain our growth. I am professionally successful because of my dad, although not totally. I would say 90 percent because of my father and 10 percent would be me. Yes, we joke I used to be known as his daughter but now he is known as my father. I have had my share of mishaps and failures, but plenty of advantages and doors opened for me because of my father. I am jointly in charge of our overseas clients and started our operations with American businesses and corporations.

This was a sentiment Deepa and Sonia shared, despite belonging to different industries on different continents. They called attention to their familiarity, on-the-job learning, and lived experiences in India before and after the economic reforms since the mid-1990s, and incorporated the dimensions of transforming structural power relations, both globally and in India, in their understanding of transnational business practices.

Akin to the 'power couples', these women prudently used their bourgeois class capital, which provided them with Western-oriented embodied cultural capital. In Deepa's case, her knowledge of Western cultural tastes was important for marketing her products—like different flavours of tea—to mainstream Americans. Above all, their key to success lay in embracing the 'culture of entrepreneurship' as inheritors of their families' legacies. Light and Gold (2000) describe the culture of entrepreneurship as class resources including 'supportive values, attitudes, knowledge and skills transmitted in the course of socialization from one generation to another . . . [and] contain[ing] all the skills they need to practice their occupation [in the market economy]' (84). This cultural endowment distinguishes bourgeois entrepreneurs from non-bourgeois co-ethnic entrepreneurs while connecting them to similar non-ethnic bourgeois elsewhere. In other words, the respondents cultivated a multi-cultural habitus with economic value. This habitus is especially evident in Deepa's recollection of her use of trade networks, an important channel for advancing business growth and overseas operations:

Trade networks . . . invite members from different countries to interact . . . every year we meet at a particular location and spend three days networking with each other . . . it is quite intense with back-to-back meetings and you pick and choose the members that you want to do business with . . . there is the fun side too in the evenings . . . where you socialise, if you are a regular part of the network then you develop enduring relationships, become friends, all that goes to increase our business. Besides, these networks provide financial protection for working with members in the same network, say if there is default in payment . . . [the] network reimburses your financial costs. And, long-standing business connections, and network of people we have been working with for many years—they are vendors or clients—they bring us lots of business in the US.

When these participants were asked about the constraints they contended with in their entrepreneurship, they cited gender discrimination. Deepa described it as ‘in the air, both men and women breathe, some see and feel it and others don’t’. Despite being members of reputable family businesses with financial and emotional security, they mentioned a robust presence of ‘men’s/good ol’ boys’ networks’ and being judged at the beginning of their careers by conventional masculine traits of being aggressive, arrogant, dominant, and using foul language, stemming from cultural assumptions that free enterprise is a hyper-masculine activity and women do not possess the traits or skills necessary for success. Juggling these constraints has been tough for these respondents, particularly in managing employees inclined to ignore their management style and inner-core strength. Deepa explained,

. . . you never really know whether my peers and employees [men] are patronising or they actually respect my work. The challenge is that when you work in a man’s world in India, you have to keep your pride, you cannot have them see you weak, or angry or sympathetic. You can’t let them see your tears; you can’t let them see you fumble. I cannot always be strong and heartless . . . but I am one of the alpha women when it comes to making decisions and its execution.

Interestingly, these women did not mention a collective support group or network of women entrepreneurs, but thrived on their families’ encouragement and confronted discriminatory experiences. Their determination spurred them to further action, leading to their empowerment as leaders of their industries (Gill and Ganesh 2007). These women TEs did not accept the limited opportunities offered to them because of their gender, but overcame these barriers to re-narrate their own biographies.

The lone crusaders: Radha, Simi, and Eda

The women TEs in this category did not overtly choose entrepreneurial careers but discussed the overwhelming joy, self-fulfilment, and personal growth their careers brought them. They were either ‘displaced’ due to personal circumstances—like separating and later divorcing while caring for an infant—or experienced ‘restrictive growth opportunities’ in their previous employment. Their prime motive was finding a solution to their existing situations, rather than a genuine wish to become entrepreneurs. Two interviewees came from professional families, whereas one hailed from a modest background. Two of the women had graduate degrees in management from Indian universities; one had a college degree in finance. Radha and Simi joined their spouses who were employed in the US, while Eda was sponsored by her church

family and lived in the US for a few years before returning to India. These respondents worked in upper-management positions in the hospitality and fashion industries and in the service sector before starting their own enterprises. Radha and Simi were driven by their beliefs in social entrepreneurship—business with a social good component. Simi explained:

A passion for social justice and thinking about opportunities that would get the best market price/value for handcrafted furniture, artefacts, and textiles for the vulnerable and poor craftspeople . . . when there was nothing available was central to me. I could bring my management skills, corporate experience, contacts and resources to this population. . . . the main concern is for better livelihoods for this population, so that people can stay in their natural work environment.

Similarly, Radha shared,

I returned to be with my parents, but I knew my forte. I started really small by organising exhibitions for my artist friends, which were highly successful. . . . I soon realised I could organise such events professionally. So, that is how I grew into an entrepreneur. I have a symbiotic relationship with craftspeople of all type[s] . . . they are my creditors/lenders, workers, and trust me with their goods, to which I add value and sell worldwide. My work is bringing together people who have some kind of synergy . . . and to get the best value for their merchandise.

These women TEs perceived their entrepreneurship as part of a social commitment, as a way of fulfilling nationalistic aspirations, and as an opportunity for expanding their careers and building enduring relationships with local communities. Moore (2005, 43) calls this trend among women entrepreneurs a ‘protean’ style of career development, where boundaries no longer have the same meaning. For the ‘Lone Crusaders’, career advancement was no longer seen as limited within one’s particular organisation, job, or firm but evolved together with personal interests, passion, faith, and competence in a global economy. Simi echoed this sentiment:

I got fed up very quickly at my job [as a senior executive in the hospitality industry] and so I went on to join an organisation that deals with high fashion, craft-based women’s clothing who exported their creations. I was managing their retail stores at [City A]. Then I moved to [City B] where I coordinated their design studio. I was managing their production and sales. That was [a] good break for me because it exposed me to [a] lot of handmade textiles, crafts, etc. . . . by sheer good luck, I found a meaning in my work . . .

Strategic opportunities, or blocked advancement to the top of the organisation, as in Eda’s case, led these women to leave their jobs to start on their own. While Eda benefited enormously from businesses/clients she formerly worked for in her employment and maintained a close relationship with her former employers, the opportunity allowed her to develop a fresh, creative approach to balancing her professional growth, financial security, and community service. She explained,

my faith community has always supported me, and taught me leadership qualities, given me confidence . . . I believe I have a life of purpose and put my effort in lifting the community. . . . I’m happy with what I’m doing and I have grown with it.

For these women it was not just employment crossover but also multiple relationships that benefitted their immediate communities.

Notwithstanding being owners and leaders of cross-border businesses, these women's business operations were self-funded. They were averse to taking high risks, which meant their enterprises incurred fewer losses, grew at a modest pace, and had lower growth expectations, unlike their counterparts in the previous categories.

To deepen their global connections, these respondents stressed building network diversity to reach different customers in the US and other advanced nations. The heterogeneity of networks served to avoid redundancy in instrumental information exchanged among members, lobby for international support and legitimacy for their merchandise, and further their business opportunities worldwide (Granovetter 1973). Radha explained the virtues of networking at public international events, where buyers and sellers with common interests converge—a novel method of entering the American market in this millennium:

Networking was how I could get into transnational business. I became a member of [the] World Craft Council, Surface Design Association of United States Museums Store Association, U.S.A., and Craft Council of India. At the conference of Surface Design Association at Kansas City in early 2000, I did a trunk show of our stuff . . . I managed to sell almost 95 percent of my stuff at this venue. I realised that the people in the US appreciate handcrafted things. The US has a very upper-end market, while there is a regular market. In the US I started supplying garments at small exclusive boutiques who had attended the conference. Many museum stores are my regular customers now.

Simi referenced similar mechanisms and international networking opportunities. Through strategic use of their social skills, multi-cultural sensitivities, and interpersonal competencies, these women TEs gave meaning and added economic value to their merchandise in overseas markets, mostly within particular social and spatial contexts in keeping with Bourdieu's concept of habitus.

The survivalists: Asha and Hema

Asha entered the US with her son on a visitor's visa to visit family in New York. She overstayed her visa and filed for asylum to escape violent domestic physical and emotional abuse from her partner. After years of uncertainty, turbulence, financial hardship, and perseverance, she attained asylee status in the US. Lacking English language skills and a high school diploma from India, and with no resources except ties with her immediate family and the local Indian ethnic community, she had no chance of employment in the formal economy. She laboured for poor wages at a beauty salon owned by a co-ethnic businessman for several years before becoming an assistant and occasionally substituting for an Indian lady who threaded eyebrows. As Asha steadily grew in experience and confidence, with her sister's support she rented a chair at the salon for a few hours to do eyebrows for customers. She emotionally recalled,

. . . that was the start to my business . . . I was extremely frugal, I had a son to take care [of]. My sister was kind but I had to be responsible . . . While working at the salon I learnt everything to do with Indian bridal make-up from 'head to toe' . . . gradually my skills and mehndi (henna) artwork and application got well known [in the community] and I got very very busy. My son got neglected . . . it was good income. There

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are lots of lavish Indian weddings. I left the salon to work full time as a make-up artist at Indian weddings . . . I started bringing wedding stuff and accessories, bridal make-up and genuine herbal products from India, on my trips and with help from family. I have travelled with [my] patron's family for weddings to India and to other American cities. My son helps now, he is thinking of going to college.

[Translated from Hindi]

Asha's route to self-employment involved making the most of ethnic resources, transnational linkages, personal skills, and social capital. Hema too had a similar narrative, having entered the US on the family reunification immigration system in the early 1980s with her husband and child. Her husband had a comfortable income from his government salary in India; she was a homemaker. On moving to the US, the family experienced financial adversities, as her husband, despite his education in accountancy, could not find suitable employment in New York (for more, see Khandelwal 2002, 91–116). He settled to work as a sales clerk in an ethnic-owned business. To make ends meet and from fear of economic instability, Hema worked for an hourly wage on the shop floor of an Indian-owned garment business, where her skills as a tailor and seamstress were highly valued, mainly by the Indian community:

I had to commute [a] very long distance to work in all sorts of weather . . . my employer was ruthless and exploitative. I found it problematic to continue with my job with a growing family . . . in the beginning I started by taking orders for stitching 'saree blouse' and Indian dresses. I did this from my house and no help. I had to be quiet about it . . . I did this for many years, till I quit my job. Many of my patrons have remained with me . . . now I supervise and service large orders. As my loyal client base grew, business owners from India contacted me for retailing their garments and accessories. . . . Trust, old and new contacts, and goodwill matters a lot.

[Translated from Hindi]

Both respondents were 'pushed' into entrepreneurship for survival in harsh economic and social environments but benefitted from growing Indian ethnic niches in New York City's changing economy in the 1970s–1990s (Khandelwal 2002). Their journey to entrepreneurship was a daily struggle to achieve financial stability and security and was closely linked with their 'context of exit' from India and the limited skills and opportunities they brought with them as migrants.

Both respondents also remembered being humiliated in work situations and business transactions by co-ethnic employers and customers. Asha, for example, recalled how rich Indian clients bitterly bargained with her about rates: 'They have not abandoned their despicable habits when making millions . . . they don't see the struggling Indians desperately trying to survive. . . .' This example resonates with the findings of Dhaliwal (1998), Azmat (2013), Poggesi, Mari, and De Vita (2016), and others describing the 'double/triple disadvantage' confronted by South Asian women entrepreneurs in the UK and immigrant self-employed women from developing countries. Low-status wage work, low levels of formal education, lack of prior employment and managerial skills, poverty, and vulnerability caused by fewer options available to enter the labour market because gender, ethnicity, and migrant status create special challenges for women entrepreneurs. Despite these challenges, Asha and Hema experienced empowerment and constraints simultaneously. By employing creative practices in everyday interactions they subverted the hegemonic representations of class privileges for economic mobility.

In contrast to the previous categories, these women depended entirely on patronage and support from the Indian ethnic community and its social capital and networks. They were able

to sustain and gradually grow their humble businesses at a transnational level because they functioned in an Indian ethnic enclave economy in the US (Light and Gold 2000),⁸ maintained close ties with co-ethnics in India on whom they frequently depended for purchasing merchandise or financial help, and remained active both socially and communally at places of worship such as the Hindu temple. However, being exclusively embedded in ethnic business environments, their networks were restricted and consisted predominantly of co-workers, friends, and families of Indian origin. This led to ‘homophily’, or the degree to which network actors are similar in identity, thus reducing their access to vital information and business connections from a wide range of groups in American society. Hence their transnational businesses grew modestly and remained isolated from both countries’ mainstream economies.

So, transnational entrepreneurship is not limited to ethnic elites’ means to self-empowerment but also allows ‘semi-proletariats’ to meet basic needs for survival in the home and host country (Lin and Tao 2012). This is also illustrated by Landolt’s (2001) study of Salvadorian immigrants in the US and in studies of low-skilled Vietnamese and Chinese migrant entrepreneurs who maintain close ties with their home countries to enhance their businesses (Wong and Ng 2002; Bagwell 2006).

Conclusion

The above case studies demonstrate that the distinctive socio-cultural and economic contexts in which the women TEs were grounded exacerbated or minimised difficulties and liabilities and created or limited transnational business opportunities (Poggesi, Mari, and De Vita 2016). Each unique case showcases the interplay of various forms of capital used by women TEs to access worldwide networks and confront the challenges of functioning at a global level. These cases reveal how the class positions of women entrepreneurs’ partners and extended family are equally crucial for their trajectory, success, empowerment, and agency. The findings also shed light on how human, cultural, and class capital function as markers of different types of transnational networking—multidimensional, diasporic, and ethnic—that create paths of upward mobility for some while reinforcing inequalities for others in host and home countries.

These women were not only ‘pushed’ into entrepreneurship primarily with co-ethnics by necessity and discriminatory factors but also some were highly educated and skilled migrant and returnee entrepreneurs motivated by ‘pull’ factors. Analysing the heterogeneity of these women’s experiences moves the debate beyond collective ‘ethnic’ explanations of business development by introducing personal factors into the analysis and by avoiding the narrow individualistic premises of neo-classical theory (Struder 2003; Poggesi, Mari, and De Vita 2016; Lin and Tao 2012). By acknowledging these complexities and the importance of agency and practice when unpacking the process of seeking and exploring cross-border business opportunities in multiple settings, this chapter looks beyond simplistic explanations of Indian women TEs’ motives—in contrast to the existing literature’s depiction of women mainly mirroring male TEs’ experiences and ventures—to see how their biographies, socialisation, migratory experiences, gender relations, and place constitute cross-border entrepreneurial experiences. Future research should explore the cultural influences—traditions, religious affiliations, sex-based social norms, and nationalistic aspirations—on women’s transnational entrepreneurship, as this would differ by religious and/or ethnic background. Such research would also explain how women TEs structure their cross-border business environments—for example, by introducing measures allowing employees to balance their business and family or religious life locally and globally. It is important to recognise the particularities of ethnic and national groups to avoid reifying the experiences of dominant TE groups.

Notes

- 1 Migrant entrepreneurs are defined as Indians who live and have their business headquarters in the US, whereas returnees are migrant entrepreneurs who have chosen to reside and operate from India. All of them spent a minimum of five years in the US before relocating to India. Most of the returnees are US citizens.
- 2 Kohli (2007) defines an ‘interventionist state’ as one that prioritises economic growth as a state goal and therefore ruthlessly supports capitalists, represses labour, mobilises economic nationalism to act as a social glue, and channels firm activities to produce for protected domestic markets and exports (89; cited in Ray 2013).
- 3 In 2016, Indians were the top recipients of high-skilled H-1B temporary visas and were the second-largest group of international students in the US (Zong and Batalova 2017).
- 4 It is considered a meso-level analytical framework because it takes into account features of macro structure—like the pre-migration context in the home country (Portes 2003), state policies affecting institutional infrastructure, immigration, return, visa and citizenship policies, and market conditions in the home and host countries—and features of micro-level individual and collective resources and conditions that facilitate or constrain transnational entrepreneurship (Chen and Tan 2009).
- 5 Faist (2000) has called the field a transnational space. Transnational spaces are relatively stable, lasting, dense ties reaching across the borders of sovereign states and consisting of combinations of ties and their contents, positions in networks and organisations, and networks or organisations cutting across at least two nation-states’ borders.
- 6 Moore (2005, 45) defines ‘delayed entrepreneurs’ as women who start their businesses after a first career of raising a family.
- 7 See <https://tie.org/>.
- 8 ‘Ethnic enclave’ refers to small enterprises owned by (self-employed) members of an ethnic community and confined to a geographic location. Usually the labour force is drawn extensively from co-ethnics: family, friends, social contacts, and ties. Networks are an integral part of such enclaves, providing the essential information for setting up businesses, financial support, labour requirements, etc.

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